

The making of a world-leading 'AI' service

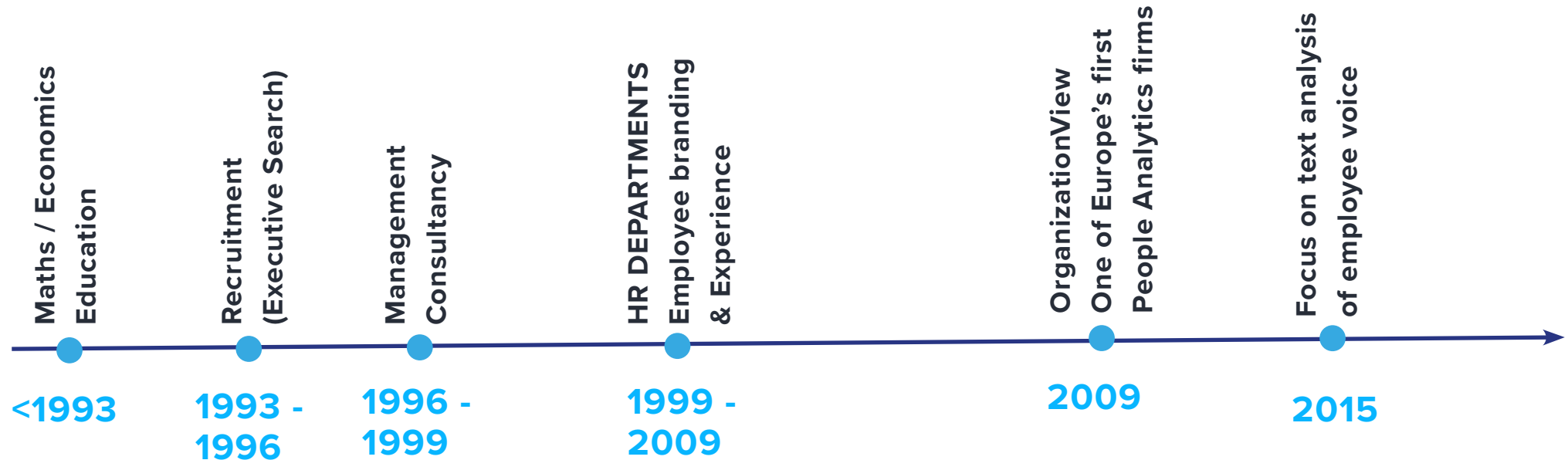
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**Helping employees be heard and
leadership hear what is really
happening**

Background

From Seventies programming nerd to expert on employee text



Problem we're solving

Multi-language analysis of large volumes of employee ideas.

- Understanding employees needs and perceptions is essential for improving employee experience
- Employees can be a key source of ideas, innovation and business improvement
- Rich text data is the best way of capturing these thoughts
- ...But has historically been hard to analyse at scale
- **“Would it be possible to make analysis of text data as easy as quantitative data?”**

Text analysis as quick, often exploratory analysis

Quantitative Analysis

Explains what happens / could happen (when, to what etc.)

Time consuming

Do you have the right and enough data?

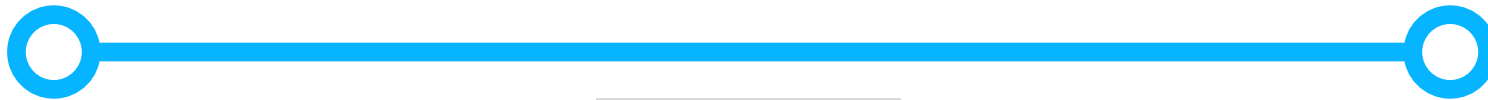
Qualitative Analysis

Explains why something is happening

Time consuming, but don't need as many subjects

Effective at driving action

Does it scale?



Text Analysis

Can indicate both what & why

Quick & 'cheap'

Doesn't need a pre-built 'hypothesis'

Can usually find existing data sources

Good at showing linkages

Short distance to detail

Accuracy and performance

We aim to have the highest performing text analysis on the market

250 common themes
found in employee
comments identified in
the base model.

Less than 1%
Misclassification rate

Abbreviations and
acronyms identified,
linked to a dictionary of
2,000 definitions

Each theme clustered to
identify different ways
that employees describe
the topic

‘Quotable’ examples
identified and highlighted

Proper nouns (names,
places, competitors,
software products)
identified & available for
reporting

“AI” IS AUTOMATION ON STEROIDS

(FIRST IDENTIFY WHAT YOU WANT TO AUTOMATE)

APPROACH 1: Grounded Theory Research

In Grounded theory we don't want to start with a framework, which might create bias in our interpretation. So we do a detailed 'line-by-line' study. We might do this before thinking about the question to be answered.

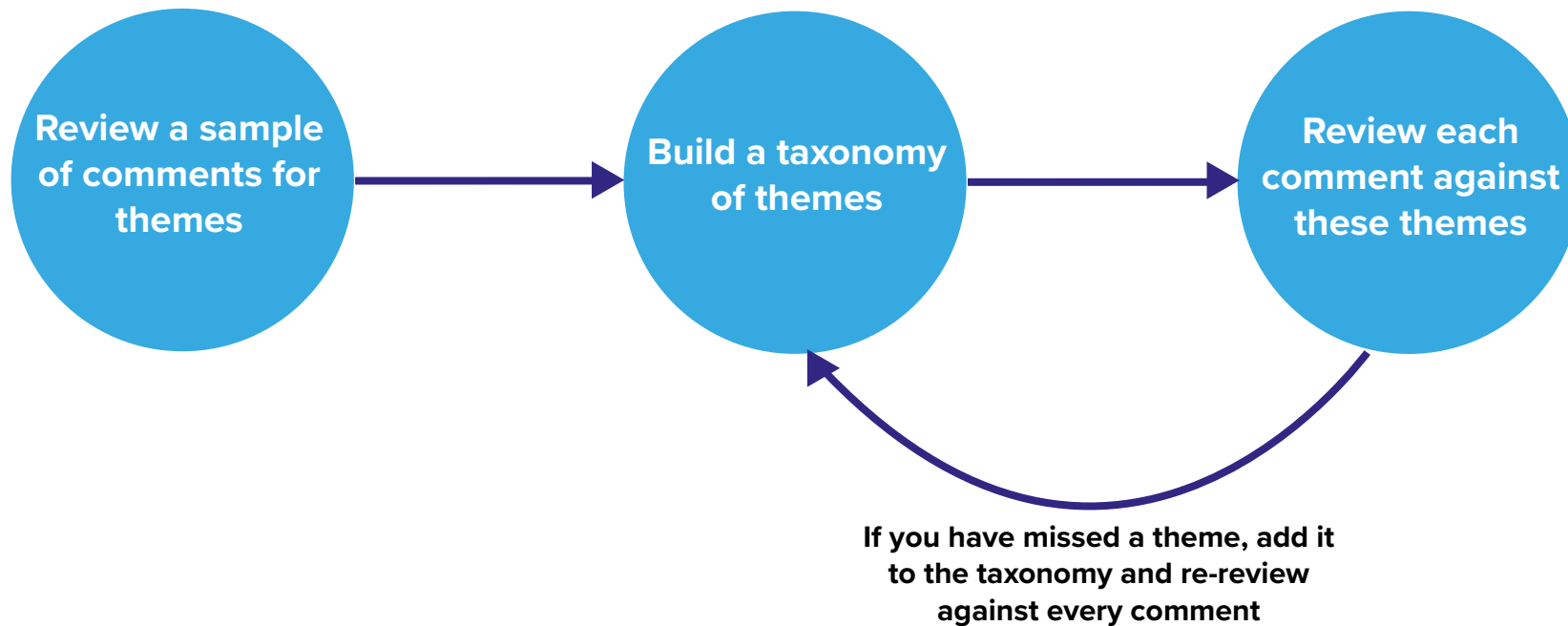
We view this as the 'gold standard'



Topics should be understandable in their own right. So not "Career Development" but instead "Lack of available opportunities"

APPROACH 2: Sample, identify, review

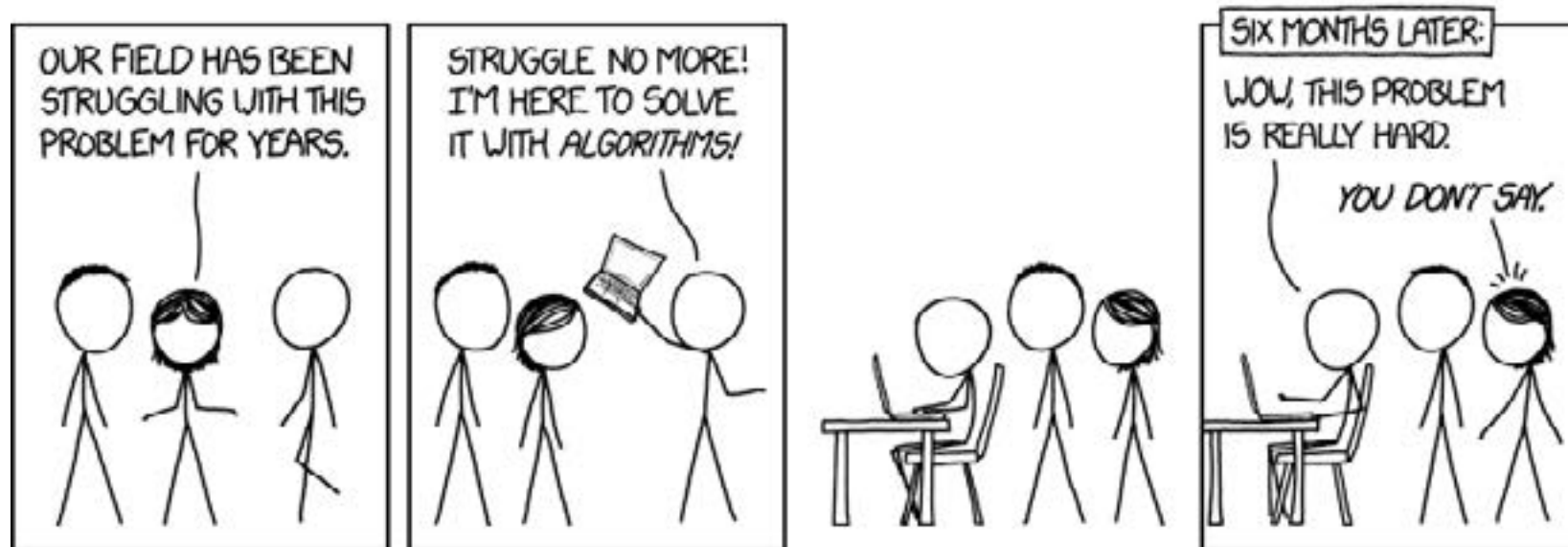
This approach has typically been used for large volumes of comments. The reduction in quality is balanced by increased speed & potentially lower skill requirements



KEY TECHNICAL CHALLENGES
a.k.a
“HELLO THEORY, MEET REALITY”

There are no easy solutions - everything is in the long tail

But we're getting good at solving specific problems



Need to understand the semantic meaning

“If you could do one thing to improve working for COMPANY what would it be?”

“more money, less hours!”

“Not being salary capped after
30 + years of loyal service”

“Competitive salary increases
for internal movement, low pay
raises encourage outward moves
rather than talent retention”

“Better pay”

“Better wages”

“if I could I would give a pay rise
to the living wage amount and
not just the minimum wage, we
do work hard for our company.”

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“Better pay”

“Ha Ha. A raise”

“Better wages”

“if I could I would give a pay rise
to the living wage amount and
not just the minimum wage, we
do work hard for our company.”

Context is vital for understanding text information

Generic text algorithms fail to provide contextual meaning to comments. We look at text in 3 ways:

The context of the Organization

The context of the Question

The context of the sentence structure

Context of the organization is highly beneficial

Employees will often use names rather than descriptions. They assume you know these.

Bangalore

The offshoring centre

Zürich

The headquarters

Jane

The CEO

‘Ask Anita’

The internal chatbot

Eagle

The finance transformation programme

Bias needs to be monitored & dealt with

Large language models can ‘impose’ their own interpretations of the data.

**“A really French
working style”**

Theme: “Bureaucracy”

Text analysis historically expensive

HR has been trying to avoid capturing and analysing text.

POSITIVES

- Contains richness & Granularity
- Enables people to add what they need / want to say
- Easier to design a good UI

NEGATIVES

- Messy - typos, multiple-wordings
- Introduction of subjectivity - potential bias
- Risk of litigation
- Difficult to report

TECHNICAL CHALLENGES & APPROACH

Text classification requires manually created training data

There is no getting away from needing good training data

Most predictive models in HR:

There is access to a dataset which shows what you want to predict that the model can learn from.

<i>Label</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Location</i>
1	M	32	DE
0	F	25	UK
0	M	58	ES

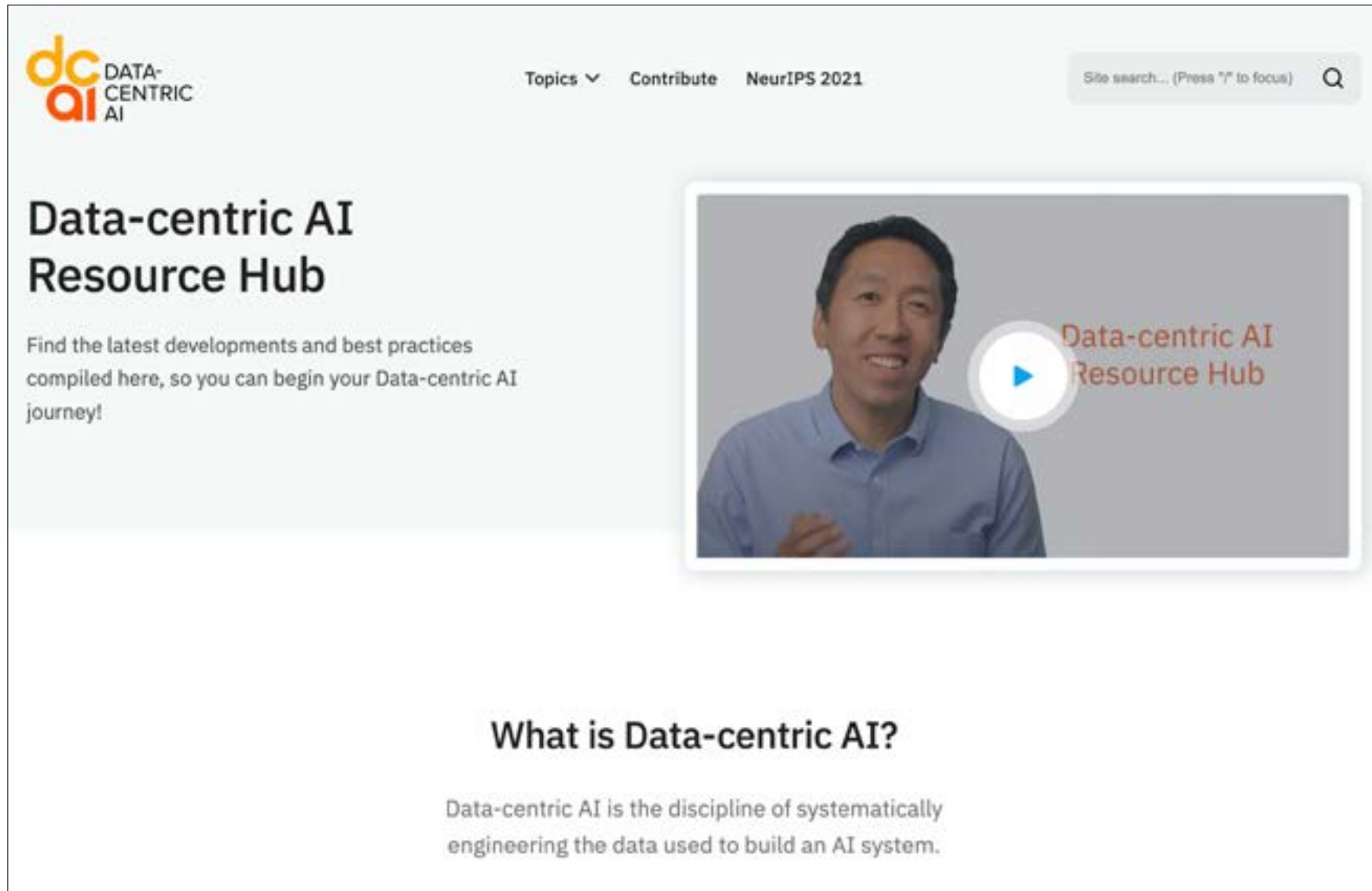
Text classification

No model exists - you have to create one!

<i>Theme</i>	<i>Sentence</i>
Pay	Can you increase my wages
Training	After the grad scheme there is no training available
Manager	My manager never provides training
Training	My manager never provides training

Data Centric AI - focusing on the training data not the model

Firms like Tesla often have 50x more people working on creating training data than building AI models.



The screenshot shows the homepage of the Data-centric AI Resource Hub. At the top left is the logo, which consists of the letters 'dc' in orange and 'ai' in red, followed by the text 'DATA-CENTRIC AI'. To the right of the logo are navigation links: 'Topics' with a dropdown arrow, 'Contribute', and 'NeurIPS 2021'. Further right is a search bar with the placeholder text 'Site search... (Press "/" to focus)' and a magnifying glass icon. Below the navigation bar, the main heading 'Data-centric AI Resource Hub' is displayed in a large, bold, black font. Underneath this heading is a paragraph: 'Find the latest developments and best practices compiled here, so you can begin your Data-centric AI journey!'. To the right of this text is a video player. The video frame shows a man in a blue shirt smiling, with a large white play button in the center. Overlaid on the right side of the video frame is the text 'Data-centric AI Resource Hub' in a reddish-brown color. Below the video player, the heading 'What is Data-centric AI?' is shown in a bold, black font. Underneath this heading is a paragraph: 'Data-centric AI is the discipline of systematically engineering the data used to build an AI system.'

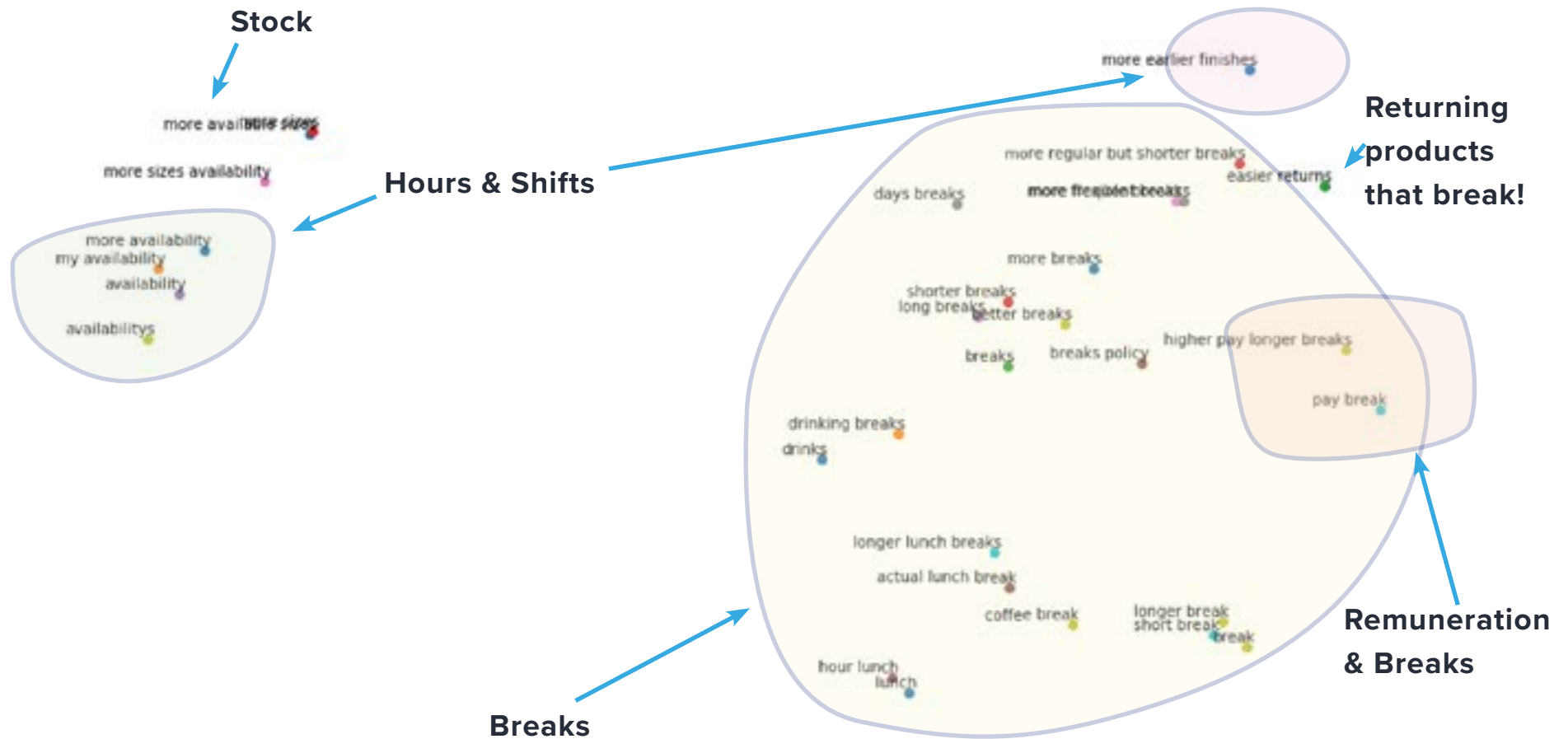
Finding semantically similar short phrases

Dimensionality reduction can give you an idea of what is happening



Finding semantically similar short phrases

Setting boundaries around themes to categorise ideas



Finding the edge-cases

Understanding your algorithm and where it's struggling is vital to getting really high performance.

How do we separate....	from this
my workplace (the place I work)	Workplace , the software from Facebook
an employee's benefits package	how an employee benefits from....
more pay	pay more attention
better health	better health insurance
Moral (most common misspelling of Morale)	Moral (ethics)

Labelling consistency / Inter-reviewer agreement

It's vitally important that labellers have a clear set of written guidelines for reviewers

Themes should be mutually exclusive

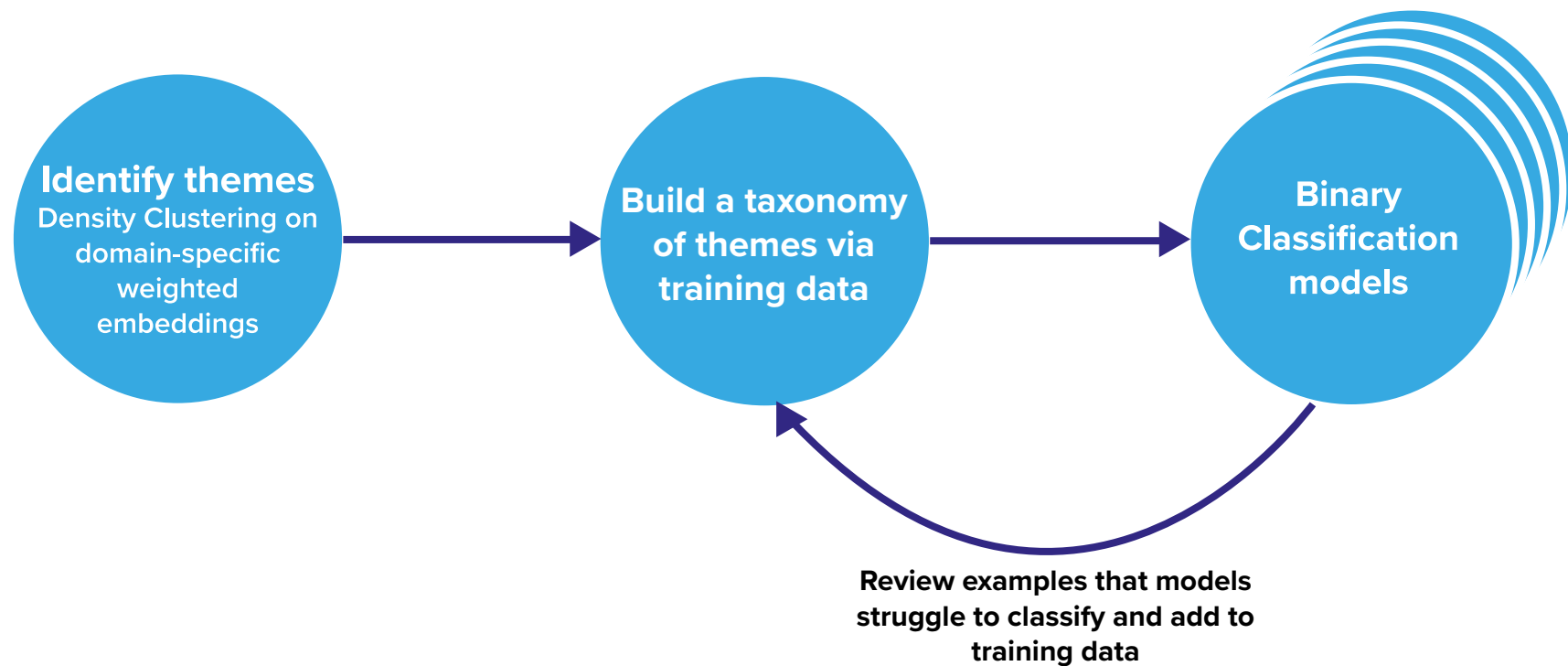
Themes should be objective

You need a process for managing theme evolution

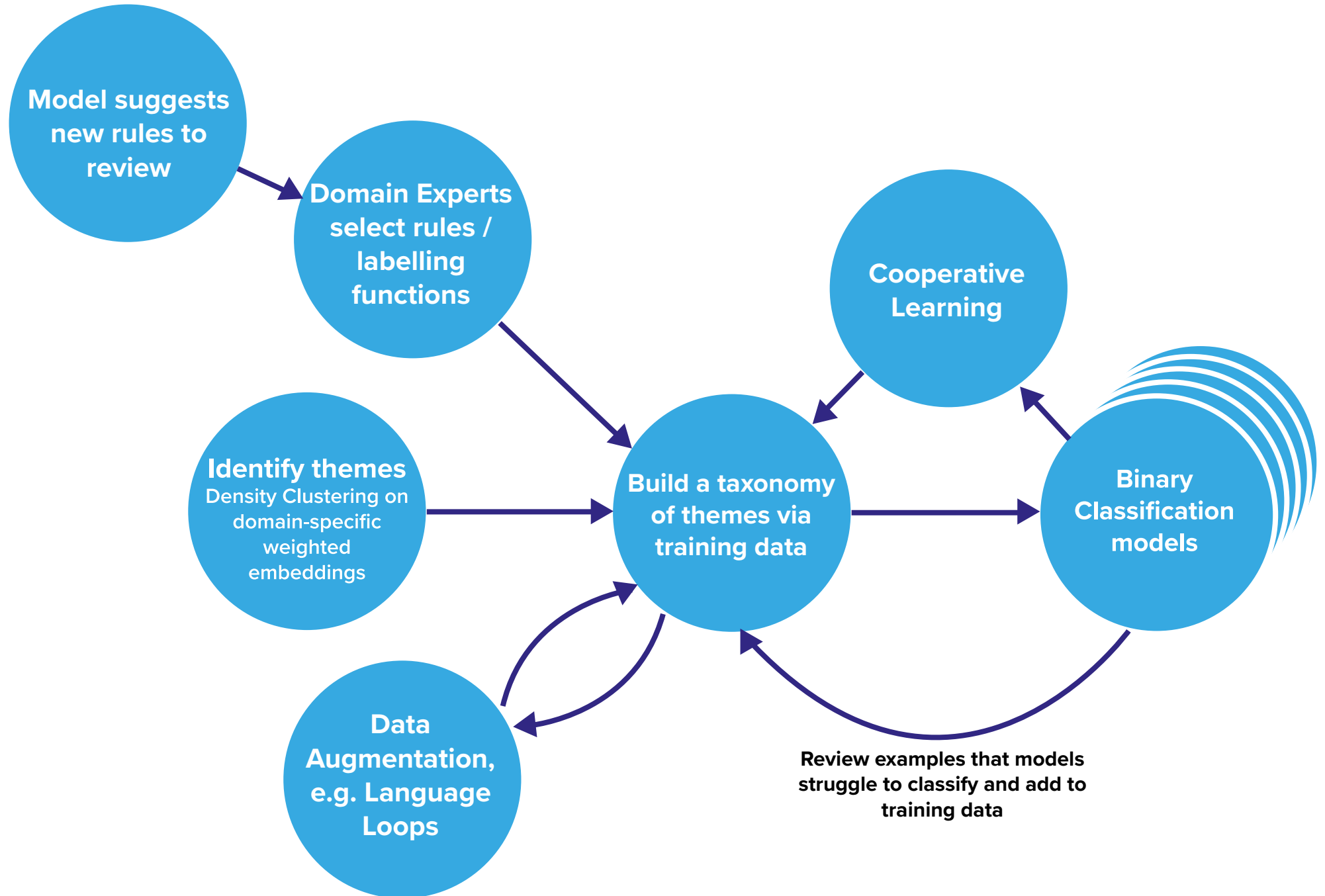
ML ASSISTED ANALYSIS

Building an inductive model with ML assistance

Our initial process was very similar



Of course the end solution is a lot more sophisticated



Internal tooling to enable Domain Experts to build & curate models

Workometry Lite 

Manage Projects Weak Labelling Confidence / Voting Uncertainty Review not-coded

AUTOMATE-API FOLDERS SEARCH EXPAND REFINE UPLOAD FORCE LOGOUT 

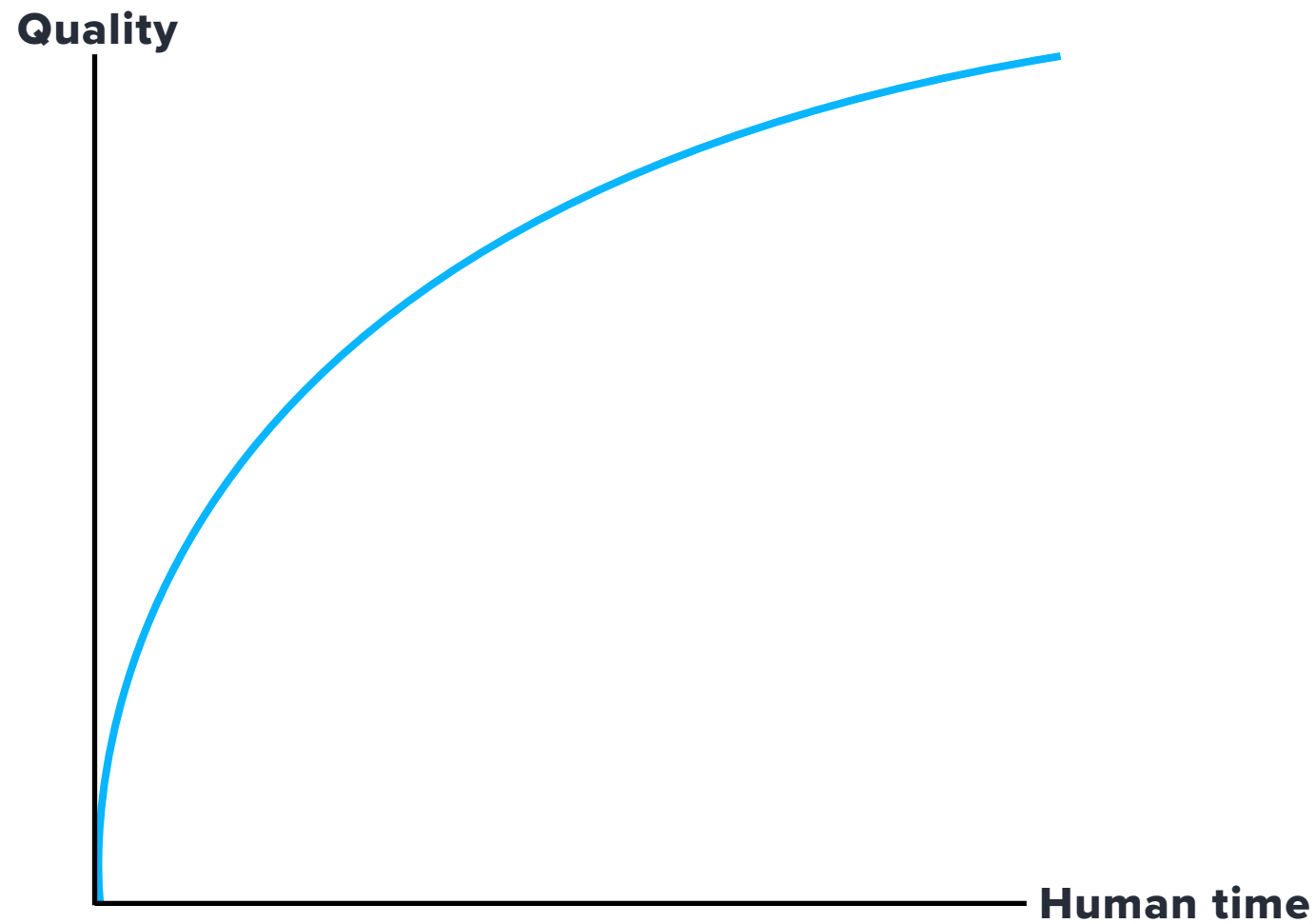
List of entities for Low 0.15 High 0.5  

Sort   

Work Life Balance Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 1164 LOW: 235 MED: 273 HIGH: 1948	Workplace And Location Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 86 LOW: 251 MED: 231 HIGH: 1179	Colleague Quality Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 426 LOW: 195 MED: 218 HIGH: 1240
Environment And Atmosphere Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 49 LOW: 204 MED: 209 HIGH: 699	Flexible Working Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 395 LOW: 112 MED: 193 HIGH: 1031	Team And Teamwork Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 202 LOW: 222 MED: 189 HIGH: 870
Salary Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 425 LOW: 160 MED: 179 HIGH: 1169	It Or Technologies Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 200 LOW: 194 MED: 162 HIGH: 787	Benefit Package Last revised: 2021-04-03 08:14:12  Training examples: 535 LOW: 146 MED: 134 HIGH: 1166

Optimising on two variables

Given our constraints, there are two things that define our success



How we structure our team

Our key focus is on industrialising this process to be quicker, with lower errors and cheaper

Coding and Curation team

Builds the models by editing training data

Infrastructure team

Develops WorkometryCI, our internal coding platform

Data Science team

Develops algorithms, tests ideas, monitors performance

**CLASSIFYING TEXT
ISN'T THE END GOAL**

Helping answer executives key questions

After coding the text the real work starts. Post coding we run numerous machine learning models to spot patterns, identify supplementary information and provide context to the survey comments.

What are people saying?

Which groups are
mentioning key themes?

Which themes are driving
key metrics?

What do people mean by
“X”?

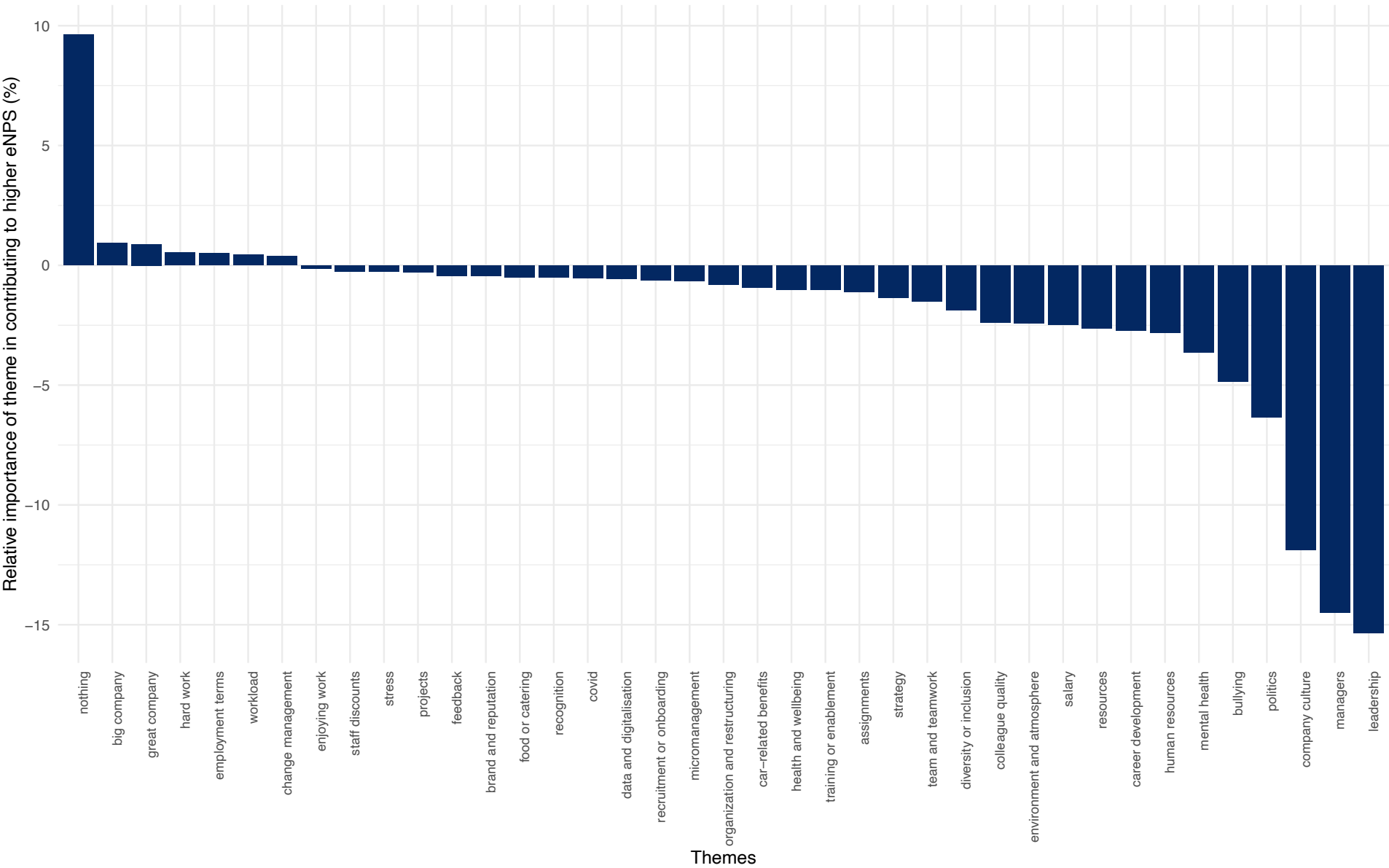
What’s a good example /
quote?

What is the relationship
between themes?

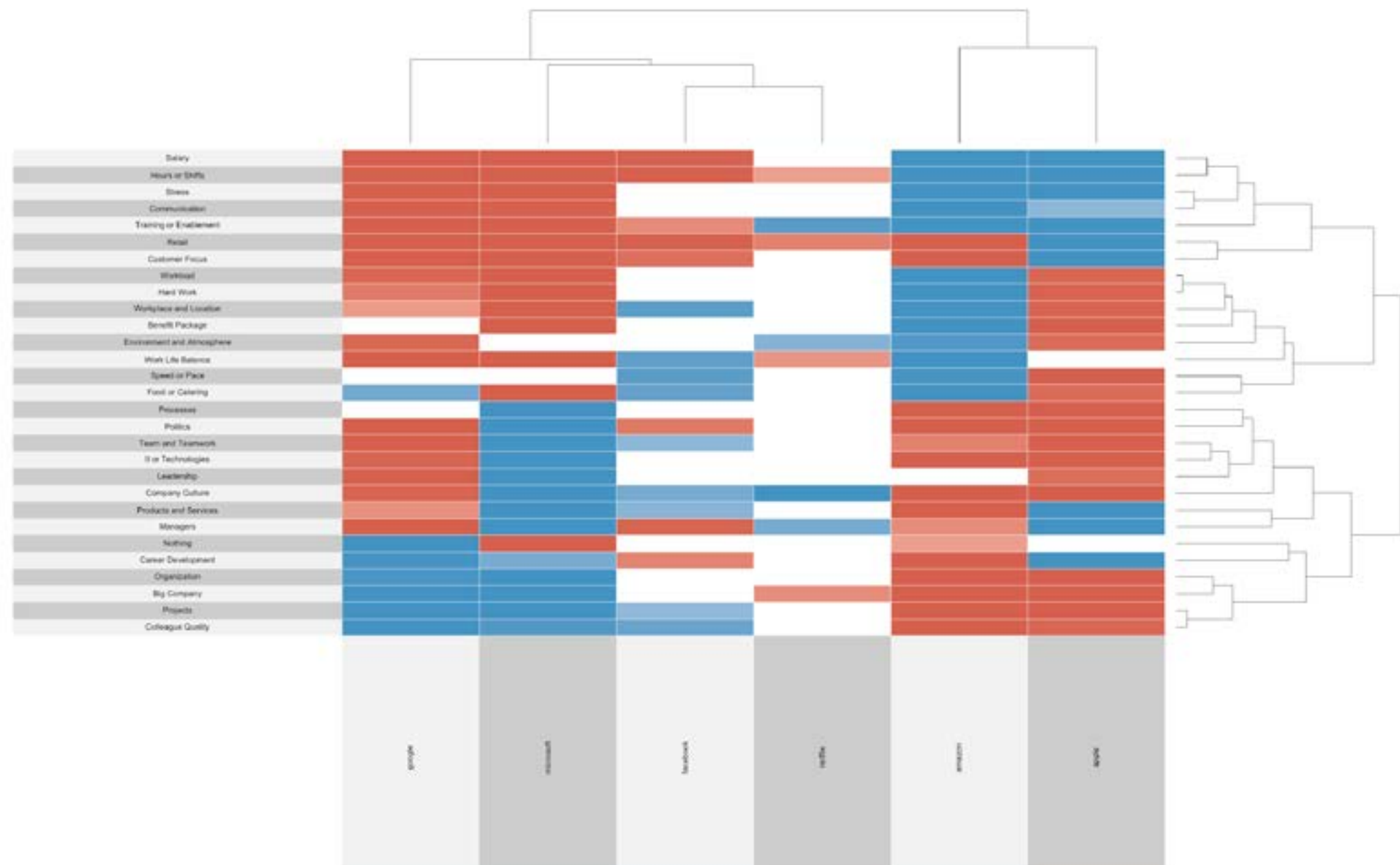
What is driving the thing you care about?

We can identify which themes are most important for ‘driving’ scale questions.

Which topics are the most importance for increased Overall Rating scores?



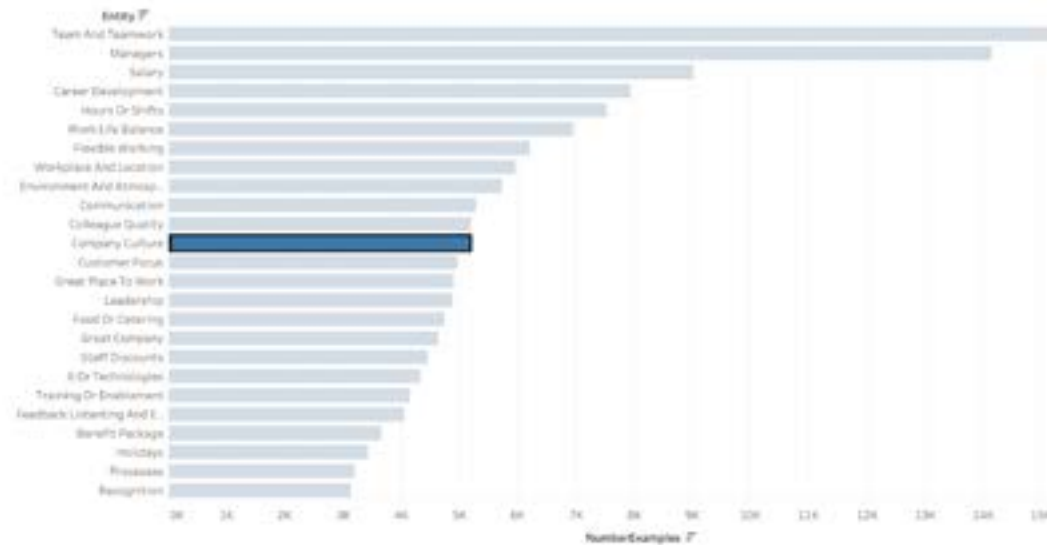
Pattern-spotting: Which groups talk about which topics?



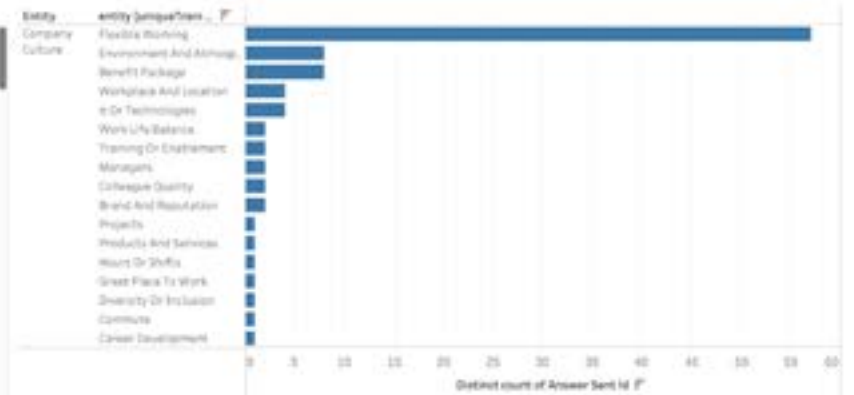
Identifying the different ways that people describe each theme

Biggest category is a good and flexible working culture

Entities



Cooccurrence

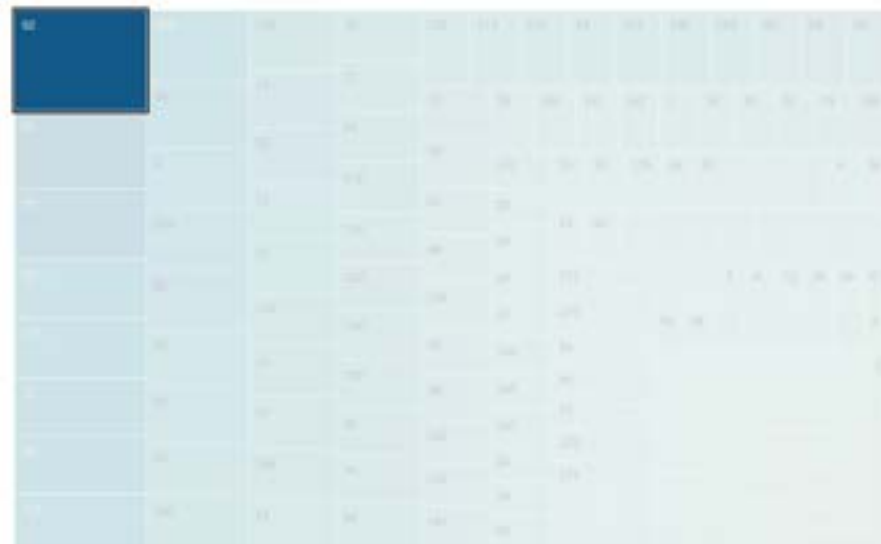


Sentences



“Good Work culture and flexible work timings”
“Flexible work Good culture”

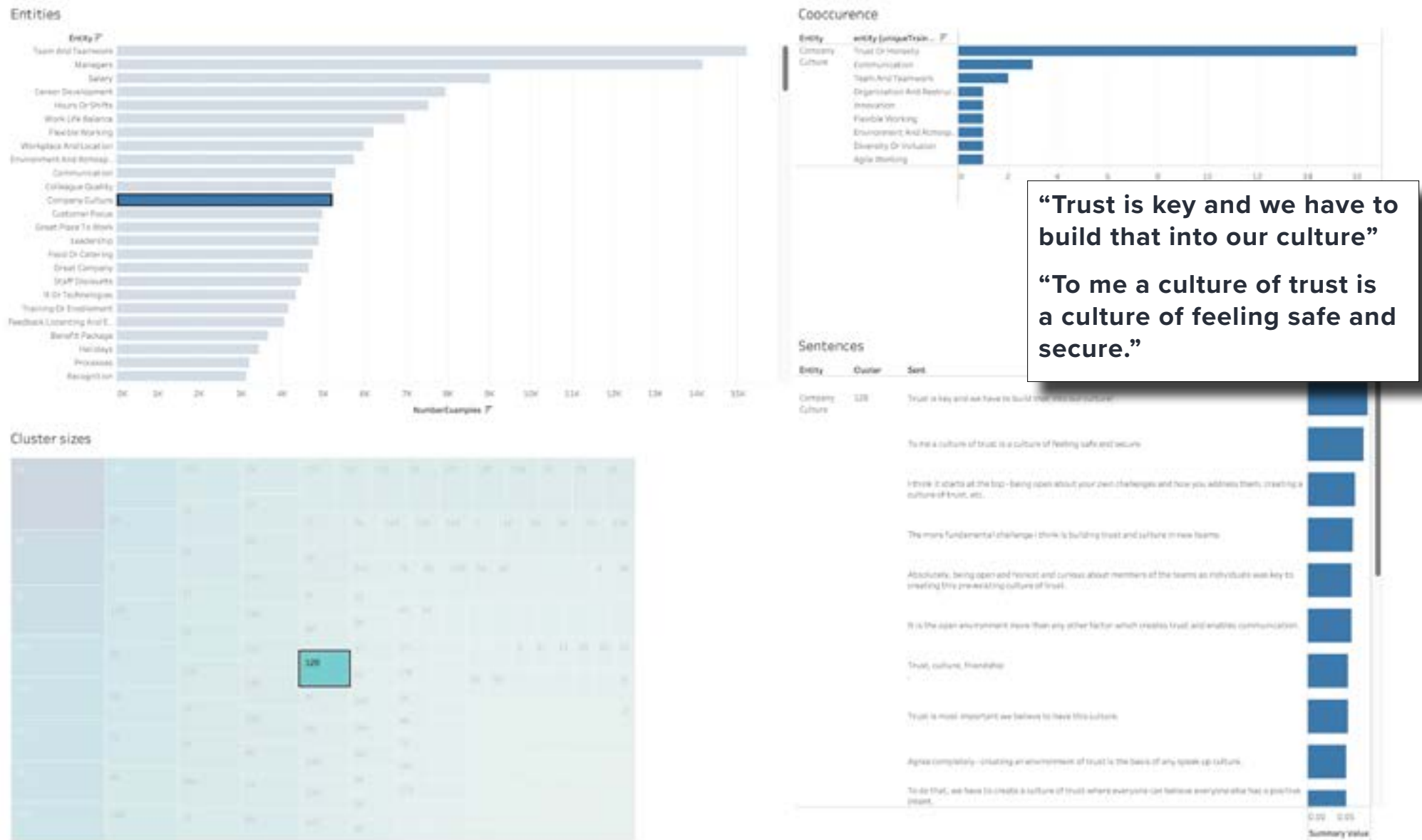
Cluster sizes



Grouping sentences together enables rapid understanding of messages

36

Whereas this one talks about how trust is important to build the culture



Summarisation

Text can be summarised, either by identifying key sentences (extractive) or re-writing the text (abstractive)

“Even when reported to management, the care factor seems to be non-existent”

“There is no coherent discourse on the part of senior management regarding trust with subordinates.”

“Thinking about the training and preparation of the workers is of no use, only that the management system is completed.”

“In middle management, the health of the employee is not important”

“No communication from senior management on any issues.”

“No text governing senior management exists within this division.”

“Employees time is considered to have no value to management”

“There has been no accountability for senior management on production performance.”

“There is no accountability at the management level and this filters down to the workers.”

“As a rule, employee management is not part of the training in a university degree, but it is in lower management (master for several hundred hours).”

“Management are detached from employees.”

“No respect from top level management None feels like upper management care about employees.”



There is no coherent discourse on the part of senior management regarding trust with subordinates. There is no accountability at the management level and this filters down to employees. Management are detached from employees.

Using the verbatims as a knowledge base to answer new questions

We use Natural Language Understanding to help answer other important questions. Here the employees were asked 'what could improve working for [company]?'. Within those answers is valuable information to a variety of other questions.

QUESTION: *Why do employees leave?*

Reason	Answer provided
management decisions	Many of the employees who got rebadged to [Division] left the company in less than a year because of MANAGEMENT DECISIONS and none of them got a retained
lack of promotions and growth	There is a large populations of people leaving and LACK OF PROMOTIONS AND GROWTH are the reason it,
she did not get the support she needed	My coworker ended up leaving [company] because SHE DID NOT GET THE SUPPORT SHE NEEDED
to get a promotion	A lot of employees leave the company after a few years in order TO GET A PROMOTION and then return to [company].
they are not recognized	Even qualified older employees are left out and many left the company due to the reason THEY ARE NOT RECOGNIZED , on the contrary, they only know that they are charged day by day, with a huge workload.
workload is very heavy	High employee turnover, probably because WORKLOAD IS VERY HEAVY .
convoluted internal processes and excessive red tape	High employee turnover as new hires get demotivated very quickly by CONVOLUTED INTERNAL PROCESSES AND EXCESSIVE RED TAPE

What is the employee trying to convey?

Understanding the answer type makes a big difference how you action / review it

EXPERIENCES

“Last summer there was a huge vocal presence from senior leadership about diversity and representation.”

SUGGESTIONS

“Make a commitment to neutralize the gender wage gap.”

LINKED STATEMENT

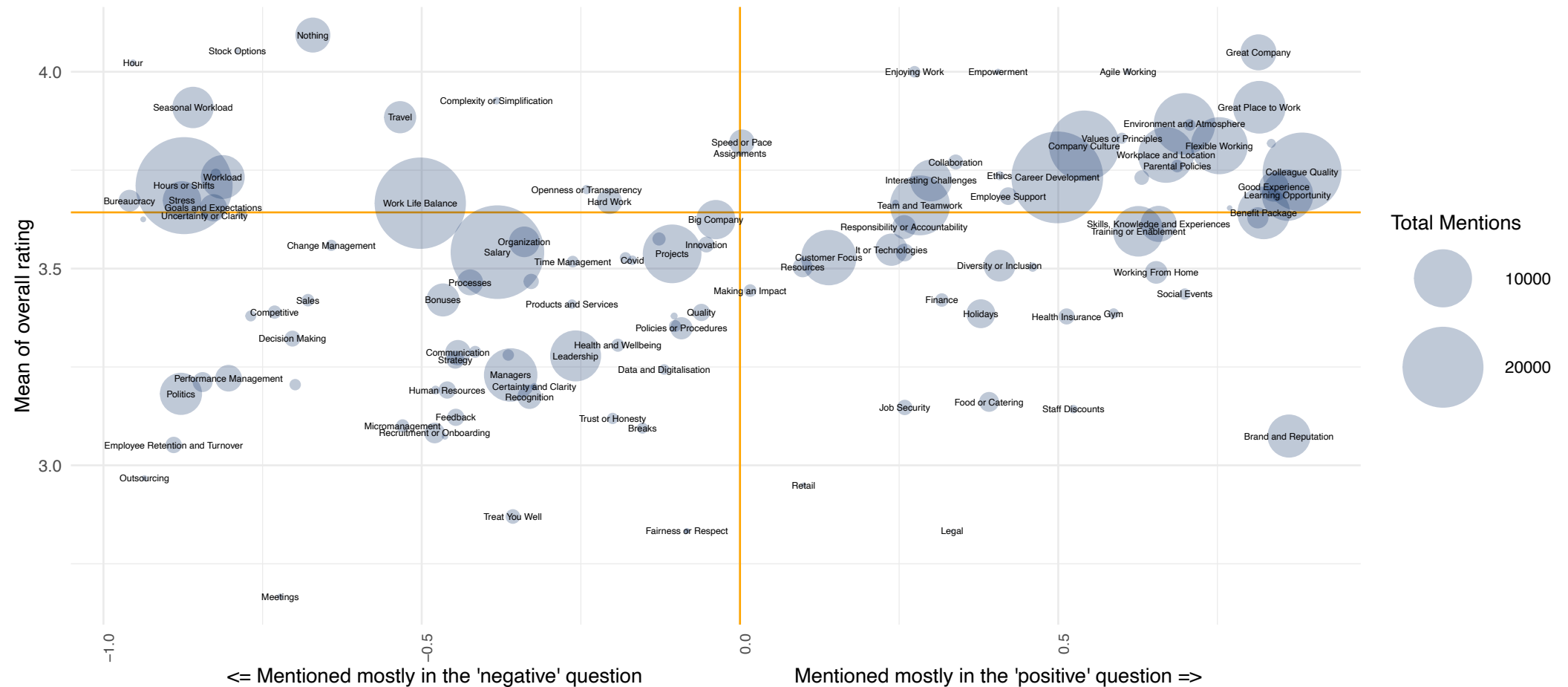
“If you really value diversity, put your money where your mouth is.”

Text themes can be linked to scale questions

Using a key variable as an alternative to sentiment

How are the themes related to sentiment?

Sentiment measured by the average overall rating of reviewers mentioning that theme and the balance between positive and negative mentions
Orange horizontal line shows mean overall rating (3.64)

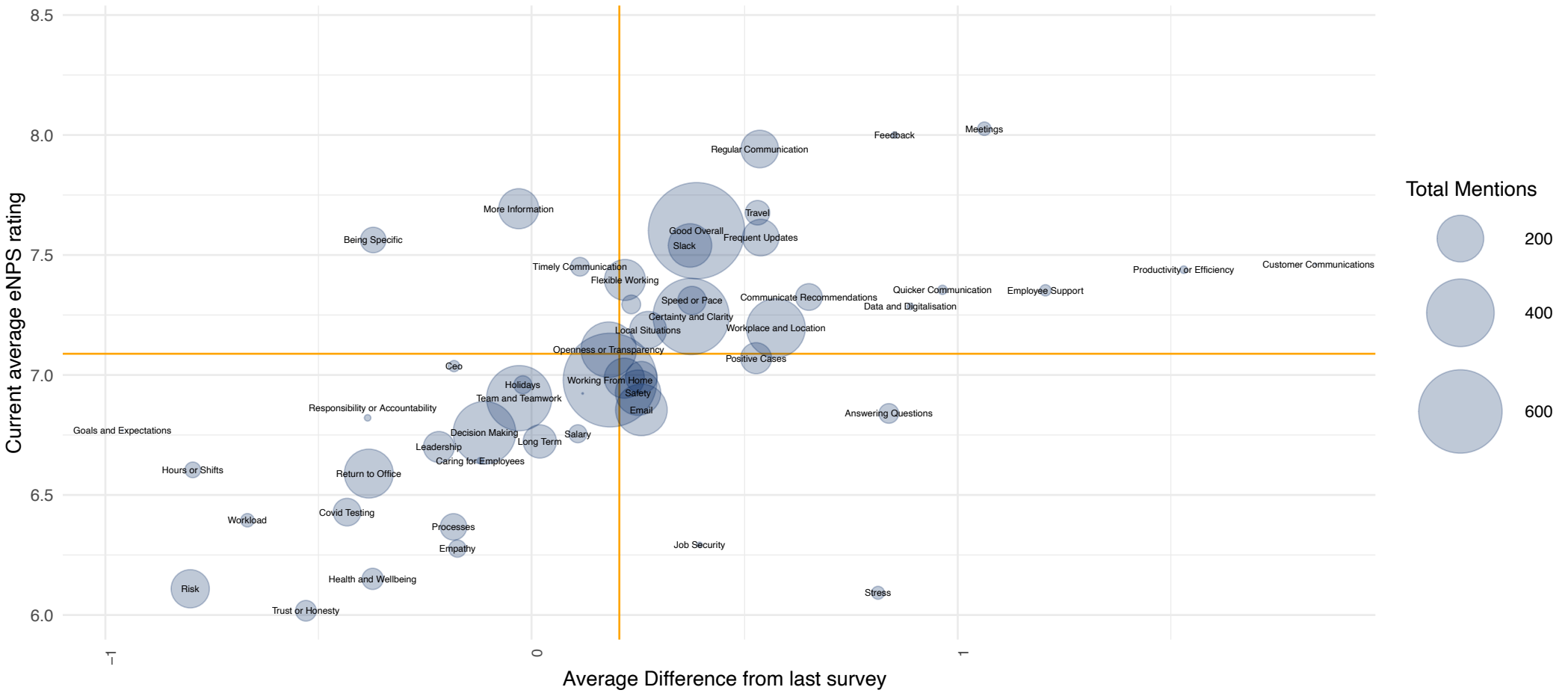


Understanding changes in perspectives after events

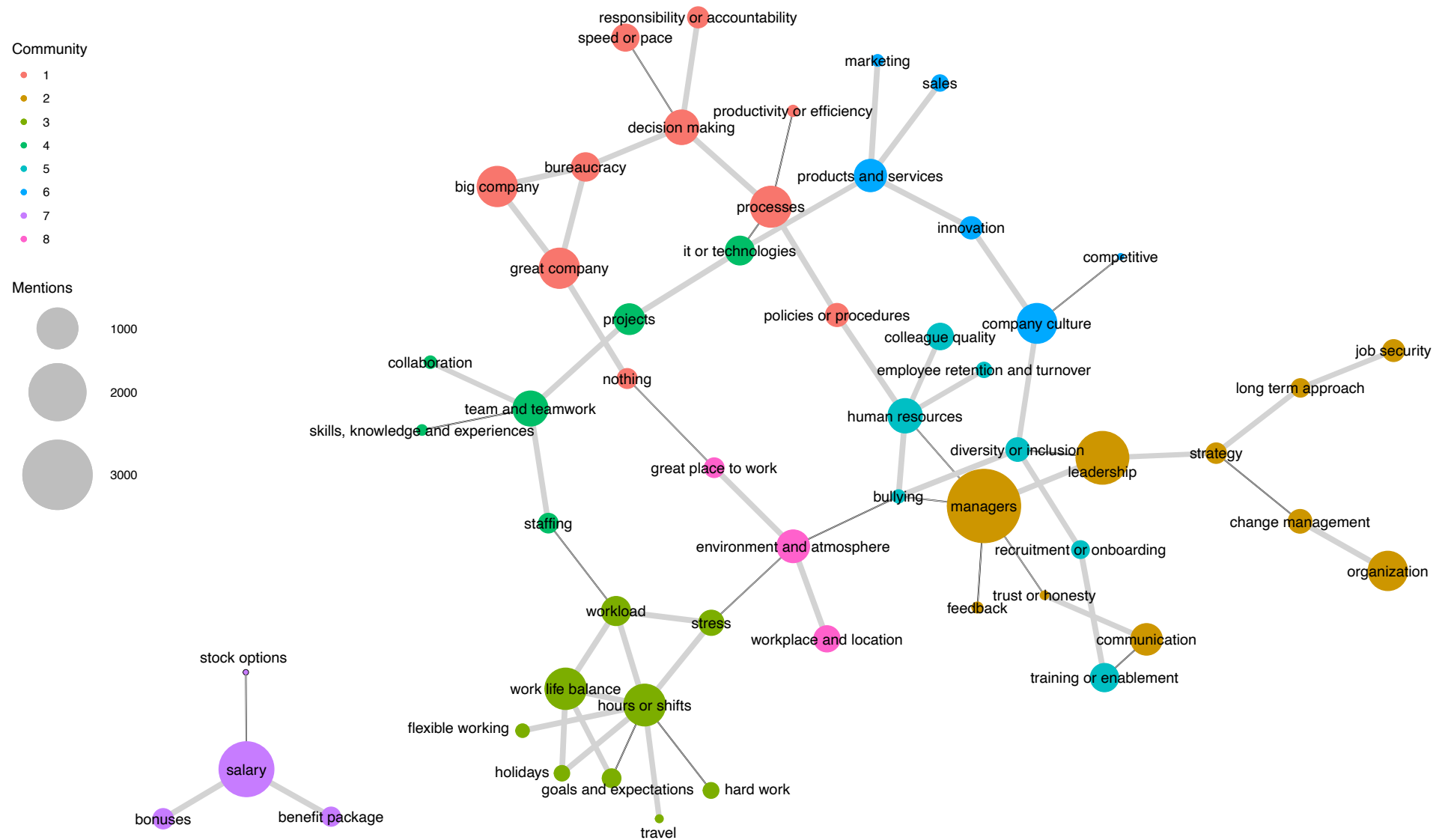
Longitudinal ‘panel’ data lets us explore topics associated with changes in a key metric.

How are the themes related to an individual's current and recent change in NPS?

Orange reference lines indicate the current mean score or change.
Showing only themes with at least 25 mentions



Showing relationships where the probability of them being strongly related is at least 98%



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Co-occurrence shows patterns in 'speech'

Statistical models identify probability themes are mentioned together. This question is about hybrid working.

Network visualisation of topic cooccurrence

Showing relationships where the probability of them being strongly related is at least 85%

